Designing and reviewing EMI programs

Practical guide for institutions | I01

Use this guide when developing or reviewing a program taught through English. Program leaders should plan how students will meet disciplinary expectations, what language demands they will encounter and what teaching and support will be available. Inclusive practice should reduce avoidable barriers while maintaining learning outcomes and standards.

For program leaders, curriculum teams and academic governance bodies, working with subject educators, language specialists, support services and students. Developing draft for review.

Using this guide: Build this work into the university's existing course and program evaluation, review and approval processes. This guidance adds an EMI focus and does not replace or override established institutional requirements.

1. Clarify the purpose and outcomes

State why the program uses English and what students must learn. Distinguish disciplinary outcomes from any explicit English-language outcomes. If language development is a stated goal, specify how it will be taught, supported and assessed; exposure to English alone is not a support plan.

2. Map the demands of real course tasks

Review representative readings, lectures, discussions and assessments across the program. Identify the language students need to understand instructions, explain reasoning and demonstrate knowledge. Record avoidable barriers, such as unclear briefs or unfamiliar references without explanation, separately from essential disciplinary demands.

3. Review entry and transition arrangements

Review how the English-language evidence used for admission relates to the reading, writing, listening and speaking required in the program. Use early course tasks to identify where students who meet the entry requirements may still need support. Do not infer individual needs from ethnicity or home language.

4. Plan teaching and support as part of provision

Agree on inclusive teaching practices and accessible materials across courses. Arrange collaboration between subject and language specialists, with time and resources for this work. Identify where students will need additional English-language provision and how they will access it throughout the program.

Plan educator preparation in both language and teaching practice. Identify support for explaining concepts, designing participation, checking understanding and responding to questions, alongside any targeted English-language development.

5. Align assessment and language expectations

Check that tasks and criteria assess the intended outcomes. Make language requirements, permitted multilingual resources and digital assistance explicit. Clarify how language affects judgements where it is relevant to the outcome. Follow approved assessment requirements and moderation processes.

6. Assign responsibility and review implementation

Name the person or team responsible for each improvement, the resources required and the review date. Use student work, staff and student feedback, resource access and support information to check implementation. Address recurring barriers through program review rather than repeated individual referrals alone.

7. Example reviewing a first-year business program

Illustrative toolkit example: students meet the published entry requirement, but early reports show difficulty interpreting “evaluate” and connecting evidence to recommendations. Some also report that they cannot access essential readings on their devices.

The program team reviews briefs, rubrics and samples of work with subject educators and a language specialist. It retains the analytical outcomes and standards, clarifies task wording, provides an annotated example and schedules practice in explaining recommendations. It resolves reading access with the library and IT team and arranges targeted language support where needed.

The program leader assigns owners and checks the next assessment cycle. The review asks whether access and interpretation improved and whether students demonstrated the required reasoning. A change in grades alone would not establish that an intervention caused improvement.

8. Program review checklist

☐ The purpose of EMI and any language outcomes are explicit.

☐ Course language demands and avoidable barriers have been reviewed.

☐ Entry evidence is supplemented by early checks of support needs.

☐ Teaching, resources and language-support pathways are planned and resourced.

☐ Assessment expectations remain aligned with approved outcomes and standards.

☐ Actions have named owners, review dates and evidence of implementation.

9. When classroom practice is insufficient

Escalate to the program leader when difficulties persist across courses, required resources remain inaccessible, or students cannot engage with essential tasks despite classroom adaptations. Involve language and relevant specialist services to determine additional provision. Review capacity, staffing or curriculum arrangements where the problem is systemic; do not rely solely on students seeking help.

10.Related toolkit guidance

D01–D05 and D09: understanding teaching and materials. D10–D12: assignment expectations, explaining knowledge and feedback. D13–D17: preparation, digital access, expectations and support. D19: inclusive multilingual learning.

11.Supporting sources

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9 discusses discipline-specific entry demands, continuing language support, staff preparation, curriculum, language use, equity and research-informed policy. Contextual evidence informs the guide; it does not validate this checklist.

Galloway, N. (Ed.). (2020). English in higher education – English medium. Part 1: Literature review. British Council. Open source

Pages 44–54 discuss context-specific student support and educator preparation, including pedagogical development and collaboration between subject and language specialists.

The action sequence, task-mapping process, example, checklist and escalation prompts are toolkit adaptations for Vietnamese higher education. They are not a validated audit instrument or a substitute for institutional approval processes. Effectiveness with ethnic-minority students requires local review and evaluation.